ARTICLE 2 CORINTHIANS 2:13; 7:5–6 5 NOV 2026 NORM REED

Titus

Paul came to Troas to preach the gospel, and found a door opened to him by the Lord. He did not go through it. He had no rest in his spirit, because he did not find Titus his brother there. So he said goodbye to them and went on into Macedonia.

Nothing had gone wrong at Troas. He was not driven out, he was not ill, he was not forbidden. The Lord opened the door and Paul left it standing open, and the reason he gives is that one man was not in the city.

Then he says nothing more about it for nearly five chapters.

The sentence at 2:13 does not finish. What follows is the triumphal procession, the aroma of Christ, the ministry of the new covenant, the treasure in clay jars, the ministry of reconciliation — some of the greatest writing Paul ever did — and then at 7:5 he picks up the thread exactly where he dropped it.

> *For, when we were come into Macedonia, our flesh had no rest, but we were troubled on every side; without were fightings, within were fears.*

Same journey, same words: no rest. And then: God, who comforts those who are cast down, comforted us by the coming of Titus.

Read 2:13 on its own and Titus arrives out of nowhere and vanishes again. Read 2:13 and 7:6 as the two ends of one sentence and the whole letter changes shape. The apostle who could not preach at an open door is

the same man who could not be comforted by anything except a face coming up the road.

The first time Titus appears, other men are arguing about whether he should be circumcised.

Paul went up to Jerusalem with Barnabas, and took Titus with him. Titus was a Greek. There was pressure to have him circumcised, and Paul refused. If Titus were circumcised, it would have settled that a Greek had to become a Jew before he could belong to Christ.

Titus says nothing in the account. He is not asked.

Corinth had already met one of Paul's men.

Timothy had been sent, and Paul had written ahead about it twice. He called him his beloved son, faithful in the Lord, and said he would remind them of his ways. Then, at the end of the same letter: if Timothy comes, see that he is with you without fear, and let no one despise him.

That is an unusual thing to have to write. Paul does not write it about Titus.

Titus had been to Corinth before. He had started the collection there.

Later in the letter Paul asks them straight out whether Titus took advantage of them, and whether the two of them had not walked in the same spirit and the same steps. He would not ask that unless the Corinthians had formed a view of the man one way or the other.

Then came the severe letter, the one Paul says he wrote out of much affliction and anguish of heart, and with many tears. Titus carried it. He handed it over and stayed in the city while they read it.

When he reached Paul in Macedonia he brought their answer back with him, and he brought something of his own. Paul says Titus's spirit was refreshed by them, that he remembers their obedience and how they received him with fear and trembling, and that his affection for them has grown.

Titus is named nine times in 2 Corinthians. He is in Galatians, in 2 Timothy, and he has a letter of his own.

He is not in Acts at all.

Luke wrote the history of the mission and left out the man Paul sent when a church was coming apart. Whatever the reason, the record we have is not a record of everything that was done, and some of the people who did it are not named in it.

The last Paul says of him is one line: Titus has gone to Dalmatia.

Before that he had been left in Crete, to set in order the things that were wanting and to appoint elders in every town. That is the same errand as Corinth, given a second time. He is the man sent to a place that is not working, to settle it and to put someone in charge, and then to leave.

Tradition keeps him there. Eusebius, writing early in the fourth century, records that Titus received the oversight of the churches in Crete — and says that this is what is recorded, so even he is passing on something older than himself.[1] That is the earliest word about Titus in Crete, and it comes

nearly three hundred years later. What it tells us is only that the churches remembered him as the man who stayed in the difficult place.

I have some sympathy with him. For years in Adelaide I went with Bill, our national chairman, into churches where the leadership had broken down. He could not always go himself, so I went. One of those took me to Broken Hill, several trips over a long while, until the matter was settled and a new leader was in place.

Then you come home, and nobody writes it down.

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1 Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.4.6.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.